Sardar, Gujarat's tallest political leader during the freedom struggle. Mahatma Gandhi had always been a national icon; Sardar was seen as a rooted son of the soil, a farmers' leader who had evolved into the 'Iron Man of India' as the country's first home minister. There was also a parallel narrative, especially in Gujarat, that the Congress had been less than fair to Sardar Patel and that he, not Nehru, should have been India's first prime minister.

Appropriating Patel's legacy suited Modi. By taking on the mantle of the modern-day Sardar, he could take on the Gandhi–Nehru family and also boost his own image as a decisive leader. The fact that Patel had been a diehard Congressman (he was president of the Gujarat Congress for nearly three decades) or that he had banned the RSS after Gandhi's assassination in 1948 did not really matter. When there is an election to be won, history can be selective and expendable. Ironically, Modi's original icon Guru Golwalkar had been arrested in the aftermath of the Gandhi assassination. But Golwalkar was an RSS folk hero; Patel was a national figure. Golwalkar worked for Modi in his previous avatar as RSS pracharak; Patel fitted a prime minister-in-waiting. Modi's choice, then, was dictated by strategic pragmatism, not ideological affinity.

As was becoming typical, Modi came up with an innovative idea to bolster this strategy. He suggested that the Patel statue could be built by starting a donation drive across India, with a special focus on rural India. 'Villagers can give us iron in the form of used farm instruments. It will be a way of getting farmers to connect with us,' Modi told his aides. So, while 'Unity Run' marathons were organized in the cities, in rural India, there was a more direct campaign initiated to link Modi to the Sardar. A Loha Sangrahana Samiti was set up by the Sardar Vallabhai Ekta Trust to collect iron tools from across 7000 villages. Micromanaging the project would be the CAG team.

Modi was now in overdrive. The town-hall concept had served its purpose. The 'Modi for PM' presidential-style campaign had entered phase two and the need was to reach out to wider audiences. 'We knew the core Hindutva vote would stand with Modi because of his past reputation. What